considered a ‘failed officer’, he was posted to the United States as the military attaché after which he returned to India and became Nehru’s key man in Kashmir. The Menon-Thimayya clash eventually took place when the army chief put his foot down when Kaul was to be placed in Army HQ on promotion as the QMG.

Thimayya could not have been more categorical in his official assessment of Kaul, yet it was Thimayya who paid the price for his loyalty to his country and his prime minister. Nehru, despite his stature and reputation, showed that he was not above playing petty politics and with Menon as a cat’s paw, he contrived to not only sideline Thimayya, but used him and the Indian Army as a smokescreen to get himself out of the Aksai Chin highway mess. If that was inexcusable, how should we regard the prime minister’s statement in Parliament the day after he had unilaterally announced the army’s taking over of NEFA, that Thimayya was petulant, then begin focusing on the need to maintain civil supremacy over the military.

THE HOLY GRAIL OF THE FORWARD POLICY

Much has been made of the McMahon Line, with some commentators even mentioning the thickness of the pencil used to demarcate the area west of Khenzemane extending up to the tri-junction with Bhutan, thereby implying that the Nam Ka Chu Valley was indeed on the Tibetan/Chinese side. Also, the fact that the Nam Ka Chu is erroneously marked as flowing north to south on the Morshead-Bailey map has little to do with the alignment of the boundary. These are ridiculous arguments, for they ignore the undisputed boundary line that extends eastwards from the Namgyan Chu towards Bum-la. Geographically, it is the Thagla Ridge that is contiguous and not the Tsangdhar Ridge, as claimed by the Chinese. To also dismiss the McMahon Line as some sort of arbitrary demarcation by the British shows a complete lack of understanding of the watershed principle. The Morshead-Bailey survey was extensive and apart from surveying and mapping the geographical features, the recommendation for the boundary line also took into account all the demographic factors.

Tibet’s representative, Lonchen Shatra, had arrived in India for the Simla Conference in 1914 armed with every minute detail pertaining to the Assam-Tibet frontier. As a negotiator, he was no pushover. Furthermore, the British were extremely cautious in their dealing with the Tibetans, as they